

The Phoenicians had established a colony at Carthage in North Africa and sought to dominate the western Mediterranean. Various Greek cities challenged this dominance, notably Phocaea, which founded a colony in the South of France that would become Marseilles.

RAMMING AND TRIREMES

The encounters between the Carthaginians and Phocaeans—notably the battle of Alalia fought off Corsica around 540 BCE—were ramming combats. Both sides used 50-oar penteconters, purpose-built warships with rams, although the Carthaginians may also have fielded larger biremes. The contest was a draw: the Phocaeans maintained a toehold in southern France and the eastern part of Sicily, while the Carthaginians retained overall superiority in the western Mediterranean.



Votive offering of a trireme
This small bronze model of an Athenian trireme dates from the time of the Persian Wars, around 500 BCE. It was probably made to appeal to Gods—or thank them—for victory in battle.

The penteconter was the first true warship, but it was surpassed in performance by the trireme, made famous by the Athenian-led Greek victory at Salamis in 480 BCE. The trireme was a fast stripped-down vessel packed with oarsmen for maximum rowing power. There was no room to eat or sleep on board, or to carry substantial supplies. The crew went ashore every day, buying food from coastal towns and villages, and eating and sleeping beside their beached ships. In battle, the trireme was designed to crush the hull of an enemy ship with its ram after maneuvering for superior position—it would not actually "sink" the ship, since the waterlogged wreck of a galley would stay afloat to be towed away by the victor. Sails were not used in battle—the main mast was usually left behind onshore when expecting combat, although a smaller mast might be carried so a sail could be hoisted to flee the field if worsted. Expert oarsmanship was required to get through or around the enemy line. The ideal was to ram from the side, then the trireme had to back oars to disengage from the ship it had rammed—always a tricky performance. The rowing benches were manned by free citizens or hardened professionals from abroad. Even well motivated oarsmen tired easily, so exhaustion was often a major factor in galley warfare.

The Athenians rarely used boarding as a tactic in trireme combat. A handful of hoplite soldiers and archers were carried on board to bombard the enemy with missiles and to cope with a situation in which two galleys accidentally became locked together. Fleets with less skilled crews, however, often carried more marines and hoped to seize a chance to board that would compensate for their shortcomings in maneuver.

END OF AN ERA

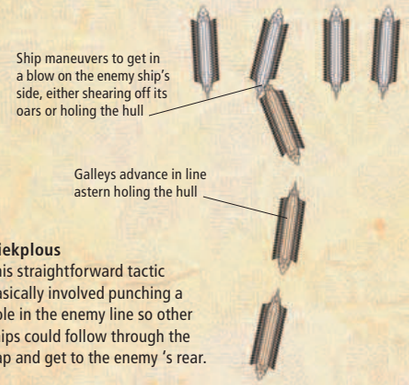
During the 4th century BCE larger galleys packed with infantry and carrying artillery were introduced into Mediterranean warfare. The trireme, which had been both the emblem and the instrument of the naval dominance of the Greek city-state, was relegated to a secondary role in major battles.

TRIREME TACTICS

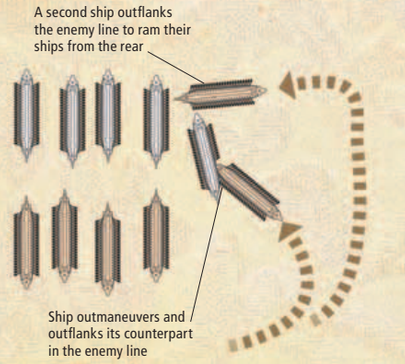
RAMMING

OUTFLANKING MANEUVERS

Although Ancient Greek sea battles tended to degenerate into chaos, there were attempts at coherent command at fleet level and at systematic maneuver. The favored tactical ploys were the *diekplous* and the *periplous*.



Diekplous
This straightforward tactic basically involved punching a hole in the enemy line so other ships could follow through the gap and get to the enemy 's rear.



Periplous
This outflanking maneuver was most easily executed when one fleet was larger than it's enemy's. As with the *diekplous*, its aim was to reach the enemy's rear.